CHAPTER 6

Adding Data to Tests

Creating test data sounds like it should be the easiest thing ever. I mean, we already have ActiveRecord#create; isn't that enough? Not quite. To be useful, the data you generate for your tests needs to support the goals of testing. You should be able to create the data quickly and easily, both in the amount of typing it takes to create data and the speed at which the test runs. The data should be the same every time you generate it, should be specific to a set of tests, and should be an accurate representation of the objects that will be used when the code runs outside of tests.

Nothing against ActiveRecord#create, but if it's the only way you get data into your tests, you're going to have some problems. These problems include tests with a lot of extraneous details, slow tests, and tests that are brittle against future changes to your model's definition.

In this chapter I'll discuss two techniques that are in wide use in the Rails community for creating data: fixtures and factories. Defined by the Rails framework, *fixtures* are used to rapidly create global data. As you'll see, fixtures solve some of the problems of creating test data, but cause different ones. Specifically, fixtures are fast and easy to use but are global to all tests.

The Rails community has created a set of *factory* tools, which use some variant on the factory design pattern to create data. Factories' strengths overlap with but are slightly different from fixtures' strengths; factories are also easy to create but can be slow to run.

In the next chapter you'll explore a completely different way to think about your test's inputs when I talk about *test doubles*.

As with many testing decisions, no one answer works for all situations; there's a variety of tools with different strengths that can be used well or poorly.